

Kelsey Sasaki

kelsey.sasaki@pomona.edu
kelseysasaki.github.io

Linguistics and Cognitive Science Department
Pomona College
Edmunds Hall
Claremont, CA 91711

Employment

- 2025– **Assistant Professor of Linguistics and Cognitive Science**, *Pomona College*
- 2022–2025 **Postdoctoral Research Fellow** (Leverhulme Trust Early Career Fellow), *Faculty of Linguistics, Philology and Phonetics, University of Oxford*
- 2021–2025 **Non-Stipendiary Junior Research Fellow**, *Jesus College, University of Oxford*
- 2021–2022 **Postdoctoral Research Assistant**, *Faculty of Linguistics, Philology and Phonetics, University of Oxford*
PI: Daniel Altshuler

Education

- 2015–2021 **Doctor of Philosophy**, *University of California, Santa Cruz*, Linguistics.
Dissertation: *Components of Coherence* (email for PDF)
Committee: Pranav Anand, Amanda Rysling (co-chairs), Maziar Toosarvandani
- 2009–2014 **Bachelor of Arts**, *New York University*, Linguistics, Minor in Irish Studies
Summa cum laude

Publications

* = equal contribution

JOURNAL ARTICLES & MANUSCRIPTS

Sasaki, K.* & Altshuler, D.* Forthcoming in *Language & Linguistics Compass*. **Coherence relations: inferences at the discourse, sentence, and clause-internal levels.**

Roberts, T.* & Sasaki, K.* Under revision at *Semantics & Pragmatics*. **What embeds exclamatives and why.**

Sasaki, K., Foley, S., Pizarro-Guevara, J.S., Silva-Robles, F., Toosarvandani, M., & Wagers, M. In prep. **Evidence for a universal parsing principle in Santiago Laxopa Zapotec.** (PDF. Data archive: [doi:10.17605/OSF.IO/2WGD8](https://doi.org/10.17605/OSF.IO/2WGD8))

CONFERENCE PROCEEDINGS

Duff, J., Sasaki, K., & Altshuler, D. Forthcoming. **Incremental interpretation of discourse coherence: Evidence from reading times.** In *Proceedings of Semantics and Linguistic Theory* (Vol. 35).

Sasaki, K., Rohde, H., & Altshuler, D. 2025. **Clause-internal causal inferences: Evidence from nouns.** In *Proceedings of Sinn und Bedeutung* (Vol. 29, pp. 1419–1430). (PDF)

Sasaki, K.* & Altshuler, D.*. 2023. **Clause-internal coherence: A look at deverbal adjectives.** In *Proceedings of Sinn und Bedeutung* (Vol. 27, pp. 571–588). (PDF)

Sasaki, K.* & Altshuler, D.*. 2022. **Clause-internal coherence as presupposition resolution**. In *Proceedings of 23rd Amsterdam Colloquium*, 437-443. ([PDF](#))

BOOK CHAPTERS

Adler, J., Foley, S., Pizarro-Guevara, J.S., **Sasaki, K.**, & Toosarvandani, M. 2018. **The derivation of verb initiality in Santiago Laxopa Zapotec**. *A reasonable way to proceed: Essays in honor of Jim McCloskey*, 31-49. ([Available online](#))

Presentations

* = equal contribution

REFEREED CONFERENCE PRESENTATIONS

Sasaki, K., Altshuler, D., & Rohde, H. 2025. **Incremental interpretation clause-internal coherence: Evidence from the Maze**. Poster at the 11th Experimental Pragmatics Conference. Cambridge, UK.

Duff, J., Sasaki, K., & Altshuler, D. 2025. **Incremental interpretation of discourse coherence: Evidence from reading times**. Poster at Semantics and Linguistic Theory 35. Cambridge, USA.

Sasaki, K., Rohde, H., & Altshuler, D. 2024. **Clause-internal causal inferences: Evidence from nouns**. Poster at Sinn und Bedeutung 29. Noto, Italy, September 17.

Sasaki, K., Anand, P., & Rysling, A. 2024. **Animacy and long-distance pronominal anaphora in discourse: Evidence from the Maze**. Poster at Architectures and Mechanisms for Language Processing 30. Edinburgh, UK, September 6.

Roberts, T.* & Sasaki, K.*. 2024. **Oh, what predicates embed exclamatives!** Talk at MECORE Closing Workshop. Konstanz, Germany, June 19.

Yao, R., **Sasaki, K.**, Altshuler, D., & Husband, E.M. 2023. **Asymmetric processing effects of intra-sentential explanation coherence**. Poster at Architectures and Mechanisms for Language Processing 29. San Sebastián, Spain, September 2.

Sasaki, K., Anand, P., & Rysling, A. 2023. **Animacy and event structure modulate long-distance pronominal anaphora in discourse**. Poster at the 36th Annual Conference on Human Sentence Processing. Pittsburgh, USA, March 10.

Yao, R., **Sasaki, K.**, Altshuler, D., & Husband, E.M. 2023. **Explanation coherence inside sentences, but only offline**. Poster at the 36th Annual Conference on Human Sentence Processing. Pittsburgh, USA, March 10.

Sasaki, K.* & Altshuler, D.*. 2022. **Clause-internal coherence, deverbal adjectives, and presupposition resolution**. Poster at the Workshop on Compositional Approaches to Projection, 23rd Amsterdam Colloquium, Amsterdam, Netherlands, December 19-21.

Sasaki, K.* & Altshuler, D.*. 2022. **Clause-internal coherence: A look at deverbal adjectives**. Talk at the 9th Experimental Pragmatics Conference, Pavia, Italy, September 23.

Sasaki, K.* & Altshuler, D.*. 2022. **Clause-internal coherence: A look at deverbal adjectives**. Poster at Sinn und Bedeutung 27, Prague, Czechia, September 15.

Duff, J., Sloggett, S., Van Handel, N., **Sasaki, K.**, Duff, J., Rich, S., Orth, W., Anand, P., Brasoveanu, A., & Rysling, A. 2021. **A mighty Maze! Revisiting strategic underspecification using the Maze task**. Talk at California Annual Meeting on Psycholinguistics 4, UC Irvine, May 22-23. [online]

Roberts, T.* & Sasaki, K.*. 2021. **Which predicates embed exclamatives and why.** Talk at Annual Meeting of the Linguistics Society of America, January 7-10. [online]

Sloggett, S., Van Handel, N., **Sasaki, K.**, Duff, J., Rich, S., Orth, W., Anand, P., & Rysling, A. 2020. **"Ambiguous" isn't "underspecified": Evidence from the Maze task.** Poster at the 33rd Annual CUNY Conference on Human Sentence Processing. Amherst, USA, March 19.

Eischens, B., Ledesma, P., Kaplan, M., Silva-Robles, F., **Sasaki, K.**, & Toosarvandani, M. 2019. **Nido de Lenguas: Collaborative language education in Monterey Bay's Oaxacan diaspora.** Symposium on Linguistic Research with Diaspora Communities, UC Davis, June 29-30.

Sasaki, K. 2019. **Grammatical and pragmatic cues guide temporal comprehension in discourse.** Poster at the 32nd Annual CUNY Conference on Human Sentence Processing, Boulder, USA, March 29-31.

Foley, S., **Sasaki, K.**, Pizarro-Guevara, J.S., Silva-Robles, F., Toosarvandani, M., & Wagers, M. 2019. **Pronouns over gaps in parsing? The subject relative clause advantage in Santiago Laxopa Zapotec.** Talk at the 93rd Annual Meeting of the Linguistic Society of America, New York, USA, January 3-6.

Sasaki, K. **Temporal interpretation in discourse: forward on backshift.** 2018. Talk at California Annual Meeting on Psycholinguistics 2, USC, December.

Foley, S., **Sasaki, K.**, Pizarro-Guevara, J.S., Silva-Robles, F., Toosarvandani, M., & Wagers, M. 2018. **Pronouns over gaps in parsing? The subject relative clause advantage in Santiago Laxopa Zapotec.** Talk at California Annual Meeting on Psycholinguistics 2, USC, December.

Adler, J., Foley, S., Pizarro-Guevara, J.S., **Sasaki, K.**, & Toosarvandani, M. 2017. **The derivation of verb-initiality in Santiago Laxopa Zapotec.** Talk at Annual Meeting of the Society for the Study of Indigenous Languages of the Americas, Austin, USA, January 7.

INVITED PRESENTATIONS

Sasaki, K. **Chekhov's Mailbox: Comprehending long-distance dependencies in discourse.** Language and Linguistics Seminar Series (colloquium series), Newcastle University, March 20, 2024.

Roberts, T.* and Sasaki, K.*. **Oh, what predicates embed exclamatives!** Experimental Linguistics Talks (ELITU), Utrecht University, May 13, 2024.

Sasaki, K. **Linking Discourse and Clause-Internal Coherence.** General Linguistics Seminar (colloquium series), University of Oxford, May 1, 2023.

Sasaki, K. **(Processing) Parallels between discourse and clause-internal coherence.** Psycholing Lab, University of Southern California, November 15, 2022.

Sasaki, K. **Linguistic Fieldwork: Studies in Santiago Laxopa Zapotec.** Public presentation at #JESUSINTERNATIONAL Talk Series, Jesus College, Oxford, October 27, 2022.

Sasaki, K. **Temporal and causal coherence in discourse comprehension.** Converging On Causal Ontology Analyses (COCOA), CNRS/Université Paris 8, February 9, 2022.

Roberts, T.* and Sasaki, K.*. **What embeds exclamatives and why.** Words with Friends, Stanford University, November 13, 2022.

Sasaki, K. **Predicate initiality in Hawai'i Creole.** Fieldwork Forum, UC Berkeley, November 15, 2016.

Teaching and Mentorship

INSTRUCTOR

- 2022–2025 **General Linguistics** (undergraduate): History of Linguistics, Psycholinguistics, Sociolinguistics, & Historical Linguistics
Syntax (undergraduate)
Morphology (undergraduate)
Semantics & Pragmatics (undergraduate)
• At Oxford. Leading small group classes, setting and marking essays and problem sets.
- Su 2024 **Discourse Processing** (graduate), *Advanced Core Training in Linguistics (ACTL)*, University of York, UK
• Designed and led one-week course covering psycholinguistic and formal pragmatic approaches to discourse.
- Wi 2024 **Topics in Psycholinguistics** (graduate), Oxford (with D. Altshuler)
• Designed, coordinated, and led term-long seminar on discourse processing.
• Wrote syllabus, reading list, weekly reading response assignments, and biweekly lectures.
• Scheduled and coordinated travel for three guest speakers.
• Facilitated in-class discussion and handled written communications.
- Su 2023 **Language & Mind** (undergraduate/graduate), *Yerevan Academy for Linguistics and Philosophy (YALP)*, American University of Armenia, Armenia
• Designed and led two-week course introducing history and fundamentals of psycholinguistic theory.
- Language OnLine** (undergraduate), UC Santa Cruz (online)

TEACHING ASSISTANT, UC SANTA CRUZ

- 2020 **Morphology** for Jason Ostrove (online)
 Introduction to Linguistics for Jenny Bellik (partially online)
- 2019 **Syntax I** for Pranav Anand
 Syntactic Structures for Matt Wagers
 Semantics II for Donka Farkas
- 2018 **Language and Mind** for Matt Wagers
 Structure of Spanish for Erik Zyman
 Language, Society, and Culture for Jim McCloskey
- 2017 **Semantics I** for Donka Farkas
 Phonology I for Grant McGuire
 Structure of English for Jim McCloskey
- 2016 **Language, Society, and Culture** for Grant McGuire

ADVISING AND MENTORING

- 2024–2025 **Master's Thesis Supervisor**, *Faculty of Linguistics, Philology and Phonetics, Oxford*
 Student: Yuge Liu
- 2021–2025 **College Advisor**, *Jesus College, Oxford*
 • Providing pastoral mentorship to first-year Master's students.

- 2020–21 **Undergraduate Public Fellows**, *The Humanities Institute at UC Santa Cruz*
 Mentees: Yatziri Arias Torres, Senderos Assistant Program Coordinator
 Mikayla Falk, Nido de Lenguas Language Education Developer
 • Please see FELLOWSHIPS: Year-Long Public Fellow on following page for details.
- 2020–21 **The Zapotec Language Project**, *Department of Linguistics, UC Santa Cruz*
 Research Assistants: Delaney Gomez-Jackson and Claire Miller-Willahan
 • Trained RAs in annotating and extracting sound files from elicitation recordings in Praat, and creating entries in online Zapotec dictionary.
- Fa 2019 **Honig Undergraduate Research Assistant Program**, *UC Santa Cruz*
 Mentee: Spencer Gilbert
 Project: *Semantic and pragmatic cues in discourse comprehension*
 • Guided mentee in reading primary research, experimental design for psycholinguistics, and developing experimental stimuli.

Awards

GRANTS

- 2022–2025 **Leverhulme Trust Early Career Fellowship**, *Faculty of Linguistics, Philology and Phonetics, Oxford*. £90,432.
- 2022–23 **Major Research Grant**, *Jesus College, Oxford*. £2,633.40.

FELLOWSHIPS

- 2020–2021 **Year-Long Public Fellow**, *The Humanities Institute at UC Santa Cruz*. \$37,759.40.
 Public Partner Organization: Senderos
 • Coordinated scholarship program for first-generation college students.
 • Created online community outreach materials and provided Spanish-English translation and technical support for community Zoom meetings.
 • Created language education materials (see also DEPARTMENTAL SERVICE below).
 • Trained and mentored undergraduate Public Fellows in previous activities.
 • Provided on-the-ground and administrative support for pandemic financial and food support programs.
- 2017 **Social Science Research Council Dissertation Proposal Development Fellowship Program**, *UC Santa Cruz*. \$5277.
- 2015–2016 **Regents Fellowship**, *UC Santa Cruz*

AWARDS

- 2020 **Outstanding Teaching Assistant Award**, *UC Santa Cruz Graduate Division*
- 2014 **Robert A. Fowkes Award**, *Department of Linguistics, New York University*

Service

CONFERENCE ORGANIZATION

- 2022 35th Annual Conference on Human Sentence Processing, *UC Santa Cruz*
- 2019 California Annual Meeting on Psycholinguistics (CAMP) 3, *UC Santa Cruz*

2016 Semantics of Under-Represented Languages of the Americas (SULA) 9, *UC Santa Cruz*

REVIEWING

Journals *Language, Linguistics and Philosophy, Quarterly Journal of Experimental Psychology, Syntax, Glossa Psycholinguistics*

Conferences Architectures and Mechanisms for Language Processing (AMLaP), Annual Conference on Human Sentence Processing (HSP), West Coast Conference on Formal Linguistics (WCCFL), California Annual Meeting on Psycholinguistics (CAMP), Oxford Postgraduate Conference in Linguistics (LingO)

DEPARTMENTAL SERVICE

2019–2021 Coordinator, Nido de Lenguas: Public education on indigenous languages of Oaxaca, UCSC Department of Linguistics and Senderos (non-profit)

- Planned, promoted, and coordinated language education events.
- Collaboratively designed and produced language education materials.
- Recruited and trained volunteers, mentored undergraduate Public Fellow.

2017–2019 Member, Organizing Committee, Nido de Lenguas

2017–2019 Coordinator, S-Circle: UCSC's syntax/semantics speaker series

2017 Graduate Representative, UCSC Department of Linguistics

2016–2017 Transportation Chair, Events Committee, UCSC Department of Linguistics

Fieldwork Experience

2016–2022 **Santiago Laxopa Zapotec** (Oto-Manguean). Santa Cruz, California; Los Angeles, California, and Santiago Laxopa, Oaxaca.

2016–18 **Hawai'i Creole**. Hawai'i (multiple locations) and Santa Cruz, California.

Research Assistantships

Su 2020, **Nido de Lenguas**
2017–18 PIs: Maziar Toosarvandani and Pranav Anand, *UC Santa Cruz*

2019, **Universal processing principles in Santiago Laxopa Zapotec**
2017 PIs: Maziar Toosarvandani and Matt Wagers, *UC Santa Cruz*

2016 **The implicit content of sluicing**
PI: Pranav Anand, *UC Santa Cruz*

2013–2014 **Ethnicity, Substrate Effects, and Sound Change in New York City**
PIs: Luiza Newlin-Lukowicz and Gregory Guy, *New York University*

Technical skills

R, PCIBex, JS, HTML/CSS, Praat, Audacity, LaTeX, Prolific

Languages

English Native & Research

Hawai‘i Creole	Advanced & Research (includes fieldwork)
Spanish	Intermediate
Santiago Laxopa Zapotec	Beginning & Research (includes fieldwork)
Hawaiian	Beginning & Research